

The Cost of Waiting

Stop waiting for the right time. There is no right time. There's only now, and now is bleeding you dry.

You ever notice how “wait for the right time” is the most expensive phrase in the English language? It’s up there with “we should catch up sometime” and “the check is in the mail.” It’s a sentence that sounds reasonable, feels responsible, and is absolutely fucking you over.

Let me lay it out: waiting is not patience. Waiting is not wisdom. Waiting is a decision—a bad one—that you’re making every single day you put something off. And the worst part? You don’t even realize you’re paying interest on that decision. The bill just keeps growing.

The Lie We Tell Ourselves

Here’s the thing about “waiting for the right time”—it’s not a strategy. It’s a security blanket made of excuses. We’re brilliant at it, too. We dress it up in sensible clothes. “I need more experience first.” “Let me save a bit more money.” “Once the kids are older.” “After this project wraps up.” “When the market stabilizes.” “I’m not ready yet.”

Sound familiar? Good. That means you’re human. But that doesn’t make it true.

The “right time” is a mirage. It’s the desert oasis of decision-making—you walk toward it, and it keeps receding. Every time you think you’ve got the conditions perfect, something else shifts. There’s always one more variable. One more risk. One more reason to pause.

And here’s the kicker: the people who actually change their lives—the ones who start businesses, leave dead-end jobs, write books, move countries, get fit—they don’t wait for perfect. They jump with imperfect information and figure it out in mid-air. That’s what makes them different. Not talent. Not luck. They’re just willing to be uncomfortable now instead of comfortable forever.

The lie is that waiting feels safe. It doesn’t. It’s the most dangerous thing you can do, because it looks like responsibility when it’s really just fear wearing a suit.

What’s Actually Costing You

Let’s talk numbers, because waiting has a price tag, and it’s uglier than you think.

Time: The One Asset You Can't Earn Back

Time is the only currency that spends itself. You don't earn it. You don't negotiate. You just have it, and then you don't.

Every day you wait is a day you'll never get back. Not "a day you could have used differently"—a day that's gone, permanently, from your finite stack. If you're 30 and you keep waiting until 35 to start that thing, that's five years. Five years gone. Not suspended. Not paused. Gone.

Now, here's where it gets brutal: compound interest doesn't just apply to money. It applies to everything. Skills compound. Relationships compound. Momentum compounds. And so does stagnation.

If you'd started learning that skill three years ago, you'd be three years further along. That relationship you keep meaning to invest in? It's weaker now than it was then. The business idea that seemed so risky? Someone else launched it and is already capturing market share.

Time doesn't just pass. It accumulates—to your advantage if you're moving, to your disadvantage if you're waiting.

Money: The Obvious Cost

This one's straightforward. Every day you wait to start that business, take that deal, make that investment—you're not just losing time. You're losing the earning potential of that time.

Let's say you've got an idea for a side hustle. You'd make \$2,000 a month from it eventually. But you're waiting until you "feel ready." You wait a year. That's \$24,000 you decided not to make. Poof. Gone.

Now factor in compound returns. If you'd invested that \$24,000 in an index fund with even a modest 7% return, five years later it's not \$24,000 anymore. It's \$33,000+. The money you'd have made from the business plus the returns on that money. That's what waiting costs you in just one year.

And that's conservative math. For most people, the actual number is worse. Way worse.

But wait—it gets better (worse). Because money doesn't just stop coming in. Expenses keep going out. The cost of living keeps rising. Your skills keep getting more expensive to acquire (course prices go up). The competition keeps getting more sophisticated. The market keeps evolving away from your original idea.

Waiting isn't free. It's the most expensive line item on your balance sheet.

Identity: The Cost No One Talks About

This is the hidden one. The silent bleed. And honestly? It's the worst cost of all.

Every day you wait, you're telling yourself a story. "I'm not ready." "I'm not qualified." "I don't know enough yet." "The timing isn't right." And that story becomes your identity. You start to believe you're someone who waits. Someone who's not quite ready. Someone who plans but doesn't execute.

Here's the thing about identity: it compounds too. The more you act like someone who doesn't launch, the more you become someone who doesn't launch. The more you delay, the more you self-select into the category of "people who always delay."

And identity is sticky. It's hard to shake. You can undo a financial mistake—you can't easily undo years of telling yourself you're not a person who acts.

This is why I call waiting expensive. Not just because of what you lose, but because of what you become. You're paying in currency you can't even see yet.

Momentum: The Thing You're Killing

You know that feeling when you're in flow? When everything's clicking? When one thing leads to another leads to another? That's momentum. And it's one of the most powerful forces in the universe.

Now here's the thing about momentum: it's hard to start and easy to stop. And waiting kills it every single day.

Every day you delay is a day you have to spend getting back to where you were. You lose the thread. The ideas get stale. The energy dissipates. The urgency fades. You wake up and you're not "almost ready" anymore—you're back at square one, rebuilding why you wanted this in the first place.

Momentum is fragile. Treat it like the precious resource it is. And nothing kills it faster than "let me wait until..."

Real Examples (Because It's Not Just Theory)

Let me bring this down from the abstract to the specific. Because you've got a story in your head right now about why waiting makes sense for you. Let me challenge that.

The Career Wait

Sarah had been wanting to switch careers for three years. She was in marketing, wanted to get into product management. Every six months, she'd say "I'll apply after I learn more about product." She'd take a course. Read a book. Get a certification. And then... not apply.

Three years. Three years of courses, certifications, and preparation. And she was still "getting ready."

Meanwhile, a guy she knew—Jake—had zero qualifications. No courses. No certificates. Just a LinkedIn profile and the nerve to apply. He got an interview. Then another. Then the job. The hiring manager told him: “We hired you because you seemed like you’d figure it out. Most people who apply already have everything figured out, and that’s not who we want.”

Jake’s been in the role for two years now. Making more money. Building experience. Getting promoted. Meanwhile, Sarah’s still getting ready.

The irony? Sarah was more qualified than Jake. By a mile. But she was waiting to be more qualified. And in doing so, she gave someone else the opportunity that was hers.

The Investment Wait

Marcus had \$50,000 saved. He wanted to invest in real estate. Kept waiting for “the market to correct.” Every time prices dropped a bit, he’d say “let me wait and see if it goes lower.” Every time prices went up, he’d say “let me wait for the next dip.”

Ten years. Ten years of waiting for prices to come back to where they were in 2019. And the average home price in his city? Up 80%. That \$50,000 would have bought a nice condo in 2019. In 2024? It can’t even cover a down payment on a decent apartment in a decent neighborhood.

He didn’t lose \$40,000 in real terms. He lost the ability to own anything in that city. He’s now rented for a decade, paying someone else’s mortgage, building zero equity while his money just sat there.

Waiting cost him a house. Maybe two. That’s not theoretical—that’s his life.

The Relationship Wait

Here’s a softer one. David had been meaning to call his dad more. They’d had a falling out years ago—stupid stuff, mostly pride on both sides. Every few months, David would think “I should call him.” Then he’d think “maybe after the holidays.” Then “maybe when I have more to show.”

His dad passed away unexpectedly. A heart attack. Total surprise. David got the call at 2 AM, and the last conversation he’d had with his father was a four-minute awkward phone call two years prior.

He’s told me this story before, and the thing that haunts him isn’t the argument. It’s the “I should have called.” The “I was going to call.” The years of waiting for the right moment to reconnect.

There’s no price for that. But it’s the most expensive thing on this list. Because some costs can’t be measured. They can only be carried.

The Trap: Waiting for Certainty vs. Taking the Leap

Now, let me address the real reason we wait. It's not laziness. It's not stupidity. It's fear. Specifically, we're waiting for certainty that doesn't exist.

We want to know it'll work out. We want to know we won't waste our time. We want to know it's the right move. And here's the brutal truth: you will never know.

Uncertainty is the price of admission. There's no version of this where you get to skip it. The people who succeed aren't people who overcame uncertainty—they're people who succeeded despite it. They jumped anyway.

Think about it: what if you'd asked someone in 2019, "Should I start a business?" The answer would have been "I don't know. Maybe. It depends." And they'd have been right. It does depend. On a million things you can't control.

The only way to get certainty is to act. The only place you'll find out if something will work is in the attempt. You're not going to think your way to certainty. You move toward it by moving.

Here's another way to think about it: what's the cost of being wrong? Usually way less than the cost of not trying.

Wrong: you try something and it doesn't work. You learn. You iterate. You try something else.

Right: you didn't try. You stayed exactly where you are. Ten years later, you're still wondering "what if I had?"

The math isn't complicated. The expected value of trying almost always beats the expected value of waiting. But we don't think in expected values. We think in fear. And fear lies to us. It tells us waiting is safe. It's not. Waiting is the riskiest move of all—it just feels like the safe one.

What's It Actually Going to Take

Let me make this practical. Because I've been yapping about costs and consequences, and now you're probably thinking "okay, Chip, cool, but what am I supposed to do?"

Here's your one action for the week. Not "eventually." Not "when you're ready." This week.

Identify one thing you've been waiting on.

Just one. The thing in your head right now that's got a "let me wait until..." clause attached to it. The business you keep meaning to start. The call you keep meaning to make. The skill you keep meaning to learn. The conversation you keep meaning to have.

Now ask yourself: what's one smallest possible action I could take this week that moves the needle even slightly?

Not "launch the whole thing." Not "solve the whole problem." Just one action. One email. One application. One conversation. One hour of work on it. One thing.

Then do it. This week.

I don't care if you're not ready. Nobody is ever ready. The people who do things are the ones who do them while not ready. That's the secret. There's no other secret.

The Bill Comes Due

Let me leave you with this: waiting has a cost. It always has a cost. And the bill always comes due.

The only question is whether you want to pay now, in small doses, in the currency of "someday I should have"—or later, in the much heavier currency of "I wish I had."

Your call. But you're the one writing the check either way.

Now stop reading this and go do that thing.

Summary

Waiting for the "right time" is the most expensive decision you can make—not because of what you lose, but because of what you become.

1. **Waiting is not neutral** – it's an active choice that costs you time, money, identity, and momentum every single day.
2. **"Wait for the right time" is a lie** – there's no perfect moment. The conditions will never be ideal. The people who succeed act anyway.
3. **The costs compound** – time, money, skills, relationships, and momentum all compound in both directions. Every day you wait is a day of compound losses.
4. **Real examples show the price** – careers missed, opportunities lost, relationships fractured. The cost isn't theoretical; it's your actual life.
5. **Waiting for certainty is a trap** – you'll never have all the information. The only way to find out if something will work is to try.
6. **One action this week** – identify what you've been waiting on, and take one small step toward it. Not "when ready." Now.

The bill always comes due. The only question is whether you want to pay now or later.

– ? *Chip*